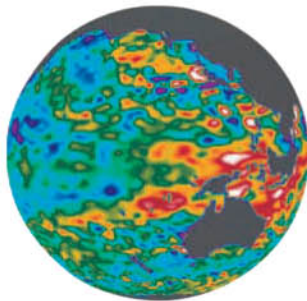


NATURAL DISASTERS

NATURAL DISASTERS SHAPE both our landscape and human history. Since civilization began, mankind has had to cope with the power unleashed by nature in the form of volcanoes, earthquakes, floods, and fires. The immense forces nature unleashes affect all our lives and influence everything from the way we construct buildings to where we situate towns and cities. Though we can prepare in a limited way for natural disasters, no one knows when the next will strike and with what force. People also pollute the atmosphere, and this means that our climate and its destructive power is changing in ever more extreme and unpredictable ways.

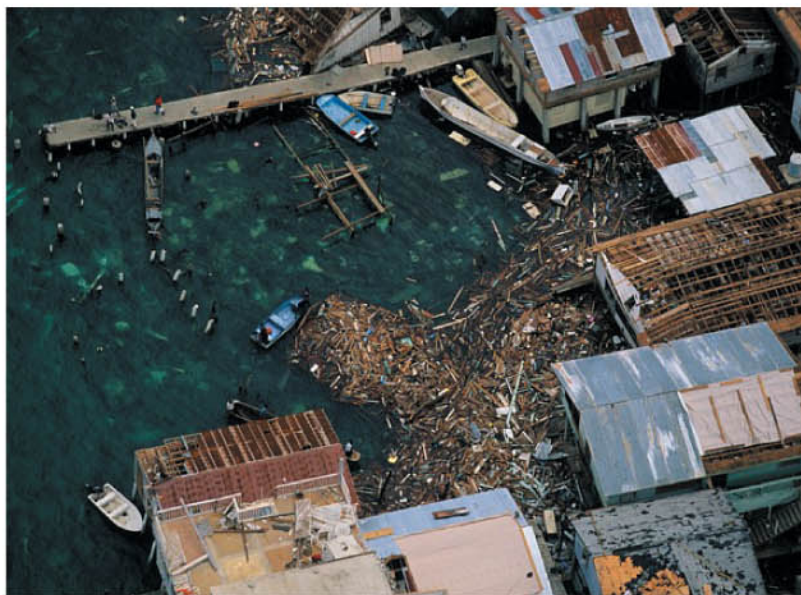
TROPICAL CYCLONES

Tropical cyclones, known as hurricanes in the Caribbean and the U.S. and typhoons in the west of the Pacific Ocean, are powerful, seasonal storms with high winds of over 70 mph (113 km/h). They originate in oceans over the equator and there are around 100 worldwide each year. Sometimes they do not reach land, but when they do, vast destruction is usual. Tropical cyclones are given names, such as Hurricane Katrina or Mitch, so people can identify them in forecasters' warnings. The thunder storms they generate can produce 10 in (25 cm) of rain each day and thus make huge amounts of energy, often equivalent in one day to as much power as the U.S. uses in one year.



EL NIÑO

The satellite image of Earth shows the temperature of the land and sea around Indonesia, the red and white colors indicating higher than average readings. Later sea temperatures dropped dramatically. The departure of the large mass of warm water affects where rain clouds come from, and brought drought to Indonesia. This is the weather disrupting phenomenon known as El Niño.



Hurricane Mitch sustained winds of more than 180 mph (290 km/h) and caused huge destruction.



Kiribati in the Pacific will be one of the first countries to be totally submerged.

GLOBAL WARMING

An ever increasing amount of so-called "natural disasters" are, in fact, the results of global warming, a heating up of the Earth's climate that scientists now believe is probably caused by atmospheric pollution. As countries' climates change, people must prepare for new weather situations they had not previously encountered, such as flooding and drought. The warmer temperatures are also melting polar ice caps, thus increasing sea levels. The result is that low-lying areas of some countries will revert back to the sea and some whole islands may be lost.



A bush fire rages in Kakadu National Park, Australia.

FIRE

Bush, or forest, fires can be one of the most terrifying of all natural disasters. They destroy vast tracts of vegetation, kill large numbers of animals, and can do great damage to crops and property. A forest fire usually starts after a particularly dry season, and while fires may be set off spontaneously or through a strike of lightning, often they are caused by people. Once burning, the fire quickly grows in scale, becoming a huge wall of flame. Strong winds can drive the flames, spreading them at huge speed and across vast distances.